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"Clash of civilizations"



Introduction:-

World politics is entering a new phase, and intellectuals have not hesitated to proliferate visions of what it will be—the end of history, the return of traditional rivalries between nation states, and the decline of the nation state from the conflicting pulls of tribalism and globalism, among others. Each of these visions catches aspects of the emerging reality. Yet they all miss a crucial, indeed a central, aspect of what global politics is likely to be in the coming years. It is my hypothesis that the great divisions among humankind and the dominating source of conflict will be cultural. The principal conflicts of global politics will occur between nations and groups of different civilizations. The clash of civilizations will dominate global politics. The fault lines between civilizations will be the battle lines of the future.

What is a civilization:-

✓ A civilization is generally defined as an advanced state of human society containing highly developed forms of government, culture, industry, and common social norms. Civilizations are organized densely-populated settlements divided into hierarchical social classes with a ruling elite

subordinate urban and rural populations, which engage in intensive agriculture, mining, large-scale manufacture and trade. Civilization concentrates power, extending human control over the rest of nature, including over other human beings.

Key features of a civilization:-

A civilization is a complex human society that may have certain characteristics of cultural and technological development. Historians have identified some of the basic characteristics of civilizations. Every civilization has common religion, race ethnic identities, history, geography, language, region, technology, ideology, global institutions, culture and political, economic and social institutions.

The nature of civilizations:-

During the cold war the world was divided into the First, Second and Third Worlds. Those divisions are no longer relevant. It is far more meaningful now to group countries not in terms of their political or economic systems or in terms of their level of economic development but rather in terms of their culture and civilization.

The culture of a village in southern Italy may be different from that of a village in northern Italy, but both will share in a common Italian culture that distinguishes them from German villages. European communities, in turn, will share cultural features that distinguish them from Arab or Chinese communities. Arabs, Chinese and Westerners, however, are not part of any broader cultural entity. They constitute civilizations. A civilization is thus the highest cultural grouping of people and the broadest level of cultural identity people have short of that which distinguishes humans from other species. It is defined both by common objective elements, such as language, history, religion, customs, institutions.

People have levels of identity: a resident of Rome may define himself with varying degrees of intensity as a Roman, an Italian, a Catholic, a Christian, a European, a Westerner. The civilization to which he belongs is the broadest level of identification with which he intensely identifies. People can and do redefine their identities and, as a result, the composition and boundaries of civilizations change.

Clash of civilizations:-

Clash of Civilizations is a thesis that people's cultural and religious identities will be the primary source of conflict in the post-Cold War world. Future wars would be fought not between countries, but between cultures.

It was proposed in a 1992 lecture at the American Enterprise Institute, which was then developed in a 1993 Foreign Affairs article titled "The Clash of Civilizations?"

Why clash occurs?

Civilization identity will be increasingly important in the future, and the world will be shaped in large measure by the interactions among seven or eight major civilizations. The most important conflicts of the future will occur along the cultural fault lines separating these civilizations from one another.

Huntington offers six explanations for why civilizations will clash:

1. Differences among civilizations are too basic in that civilizations are differentiated from each other by history, language, culture, tradition, and, most importantly, religion. These fundamental differences are the product of centuries and the foundations of different civilizations, meaning they will not be gone soon.
2. The world is becoming a smaller place. As a result, interactions across the world are increasing, which intensify "civilization consciousness" and the awareness of differences between civilizations and commonalities within civilizations.
3. Due to economic modernization and social change, people are separated from longstanding local identities. Instead, religion has replaced this gap, which provides a basis for identity and commitment that transcends national boundaries and unites civilizations.
4. The growth of civilization-consciousness is enhanced by the dual role of the West. On the one hand, the West is at a peak of power. At the same time, a return-to-the-roots phenomenon is occurring among non-Western civilizations. A West at the peak of its power confronts non-Western countries that increasingly have the desire, the will and the resources to shape the world in non-Western ways.
5. Cultural characteristics and differences are less mutable and hence less easily compromised and resolved than political and economic ones.
6. Economic regionalism is increasing. Successful economic regionalism will reinforce civilization-consciousness. Economic regionalism may succeed only when it is rooted in a common civilization

Core state and fault line conflicts:-

Intercivilizational conflict manifests itself in two forms: fault line conflicts and core state conflicts.

1. Fault line conflicts are on a local level and occur between adjacent states belonging to different civilizations or within states that are home to populations from different civilizations.

Core state conflicts are on a global level between the major states of different civilizations.
Core state conflicts can arise out of fault line conflicts when core states become involved.
Conflicts may result from a number of causes, such as: relative influence or power (military or economic), discrimination against people from a different civilization, intervention to protect citizens in a different civilization, or different values and culture, particularly when one civilization attempts to impose its values on people of a different civilization.

Human history: a result of clash of civilizations:-

For a century and a half after the emergence of the modern international system with the Peace of Westphalia, the conflicts of the Western world were largely among princes—emperors, absolute monarchs and constitutional monarchs attempting to expand their bureaucracies, their armies, their mercantilist economic strength and, most important, the territory they ruled. In the process they created nation states, and beginning with the French Revolution the principal lines of conflict were between nations rather than princes. In 1793, as R. R. Palmer put it, "The wars of kings were over; the wars of peoples had begun." This nineteenth-century pattern lasted until the end of World War I. Then, as a result of the Russian Revolution and the reaction against it, the conflict of nations yielded to the conflict of ideologies, first among communism, fascism—Nazism and liberal democracy, and then between communism and liberal democracy. During the Cold War, this latter conflict became embodied in the struggle between the two superpowers, neither of which was a nation state in the classical European sense and each of which defined its identity in terms of its ideology.

The West versus the Rest:-

The West is now at an extraordinary peak of power in relation to other civilizations. Its superpower opponent has disappeared from the map. Military conflict among Western states is unthinkable, and Western military power is unrivaled. Apart from Japan, the West faces no economic challenge. It dominates international political and security institutions. Global political and security issues are effectively settled by a directorate of the United States, Britain and France, world economic issues by a directorate of the United States, Germany and Japan, all which maintain extraordinarily close relations with each other to the exclusion of lesser and largely non-Western countries. Through IMF and other international economic institutions the West promotes its economic interest and imposes on other nations the economic policies it thinks appropriate.

In the future the central axis of world politics tends to be the conflict between Western and non-Western civilizations the conflict between "the West and the Rest".

There are three forms of general and fundamental actions that non-Western civilization can take in response to Western countries:-

■ Isolation

Non-Western countries can attempt to achieve isolation in order to preserve their own values and protect themselves from Western invasion. However, Huntington argues that the costs of this action are high and only a few states can pursue it.

Band-wagoning

second alternative is equivalent of "band-wagoning" According to this non-Western countries can join and accept Western values and institutions.

Balance of power

Non-Western countries can make an effort to balance Western power through modernization. They can develop economic, military power and cooperate with other non-Western countries against the West while still preserving their own values and institutions.

The increasing power of non-Western civilizations in international society will make the West begin to develop a better understanding of the cultural fundamentals underlying other civilizations. Therefore, Western civilization will cease to be regarded as "universal" but different civilizations will learn to coexist and join to shape the future world.

Conclusions:-

Western civilizations is both western and modern. Non western civilizations have attempted to become modern without becoming western. Up to date only Japan has fully succeed in this quest. Non western civilizations will continue to attempt to acquire the wealth , technology; skills , machines and weapons that are part of being modern. their economic and military strength relative to the west will increase.

Hence the west will increasingly have to accommodate these non-western modern civilizations whose power approaches that of the west but whose values and interest differ significantly from those of the west.

For relevant future there will be no universal civilization, but instead a world of different civilizations , each of which will have to learn to co-exist with other